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ELECTION 2026

A flood of outside money nets split return

Super PACs pour into local races, but wins still not done deal

By Olivia Olander and Jake Sheridan
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The flood of outside money that reshaped Illinois' Democratic primaries on Tuesday delivered uneven returns for the big-money interests that fueled it.

So-called super PACs, or political action committees with unlimited raising and spending power, and aligned organizations poured nearly \$33 million into four closely watched Chicago-area congressional races — an unprecedented sum for House primaries in the state. Outside groups spent about \$23 million in the Democratic Senate primary, according to Federal Election Commission filings.

Much of that spending came from groups tied to the American Israel Public Affairs Committee, or AIPAC, as well as major investments from cryptocurrency and artificial intelligence advocacy groups.

But despite the scale of that spending, victories were far from guaranteed.

The preferred candidates of AIPAC or closely tied PACs prevailed in two Chicago-area Democratic congressional primaries and lost in two others, including the high-profile 9th Congressional District contest where Evanston Mayor Daniel Biss defeated AIPAC-supported state Sen. Laura Fine as well as progressive commentator Kat Abughazaleh.

See **MONEY** on Page A5

Croke wins nomination for Illinois comptroller

North Side lawmaker edges out Villa to win in Democratic race

By Jeremy Gerner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

SPRINGFIELD — In a race that took nearly two full days to decide, North Side lawmaker Margaret Croke secured the Democratic nomination for Illinois comptroller on Thursday, edging out west suburban state Sen. Karina Villa.

With 92% of the estimated vote totals counted, Croke of Chicago won with 34.6%, followed by Villa of West Chicago, who had 32.3%, according to The Associated Press. Lake County Treasurer Holly Kim of Mundelein finished in third place with 24.4%, and state Rep. Stephanie Kifowit of Oswego finished last with 8.7%, the AP results showed.

Although Croke had said late on Tuesday that she was confident she would prevail, the race had been too close to call, with Villa refusing to concede even as Croke held a steady but narrow lead. The AP called the race for Croke on Thursday afternoon.

In a brief interview Thursday after the AP called the race, Croke said she was “incredibly honored” to have the trust and support of “so many different people across the state.”

“I take this really seriously and I’m excited to go into a general

See **CROKE** on Page A4

March madness begins amid a betting bonanza



Indiana fans walk past the FanDuel Sportsbook inside the United Center during the first round of the Big Ten Tournament on March 10.

CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

How NCAA tries to ensure game integrity amid gambling boom and latest point-shaving scandal

By Colleen Kane
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

When the 136 NCAA Tournament teams were revealed Sunday night, the bracket and betting bonanza began.

Americans are expected to legally wager more than \$3.3 billion on the Division I men's and women's basketball tournaments over the next three weeks, according to the American Gaming Association.

But exactly two months before Selection Sunday, the NCAA was dealing with a different kind

of betting madness, as details emerged in one of the most widespread game-fixing cases in the history of college basketball. Federal prosecutors charged 26 people — including three former DePaul players — in a point-shaving scheme that allegedly involved 39 players on 17 Division I teams manipulating 29 games.

Game integrity issues always have been a concern in sports, including college basketball.

In the 1950s, another large scheme involved more than 30

See **NCAA** on Page A4

TOURNAMENT IN FULL SWING: It didn't take long for the first big upset in the men's NCAA Tournament, as 12th-seeded High Point stunned No. 5 seed Wisconsin 83-82. Meanwhile, Duke escaped No. 16 Siena 71-65. On the women's side, South Carolina seeks a third title in five years. **Sports**



The honorary César Chavez street sign marks a stretch of South Blue Island Avenue on Thursday in Chicago's Pilsen neighborhood.

BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

City's schools, parks consider renaming Chavez monuments

Many left reeling after bombshell sexual abuse allegations against the Latino labor leader

By Rebecca Johnson, Laura Turbay and Hope Moses
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

It has been more than 50 years since the Rev. Jorge Morales boarded a plane from Chicago headed toward Coachella, California, to join a picket line in support of higher pay and benefits for farmworkers.

But the now 78-year-old Elmhurst resident can still remember César Chavez, the prominent co-founder of the United Farm Workers. He believed Chavez to be a man of

“high integrity” who showed unwavering support to the farmworkers' struggle.

That's why he called the recent sexual abuse allegations leveled against Chavez so “unexpected.” Most of all, he's heartbroken for the victims, Morales said.

“There's no way to justify violence against women and particularly vulnerable young girls,” Morales told the Tribune Thursday. He also said, “It suddenly damages enormously and erases what Cesar left as a legacy of championing justice.”

Morales is one of many

THE INVESTIGATION: The late labor icon accused of abuse and rape, The New York Times finds. **Nation & World, Page B5**

Chicagoland residents left reeling after a bombshell New York Times investigation revealed that the revered Latino labor leader allegedly groomed and sexually assaulted girls and women who worked in the movement, including Dolores Huerta, a UFW co-founder and renowned leader in her own right.

“Unfortunately, he used some

of his great leadership to abuse women and children — it's really awful,” Huerta told The New York Times.

The reaction to Wednesday's story was swift and immediate as activists, elected officials and other leaders across the country began talking about changing institutions named in Chavez's honor. On Thursday, Chicago Public Schools said in a statement that it has begun the process to consider a name change for César E. Chavez Multicultural Academic

See **CHAVEZ** on Page A2

INSIDE

Iran hits energy sites across Gulf

Iran intensified its attacks on oil and natural gas facilities around the Persian Gulf on Thursday, raising the stakes in a war sending shock waves through the global economy. **Nation & World, Page B4**

Board revokes ASPIRA's charter

The Chicago Board of Education voted unanimously on Thursday to revoke the charter of the ASPIRA network, ending months of uncertainty over the operator's schools. **Chicagoland, Page A3**



AMAZON MGM STUDIOS

A sweeping epic with a lot of heart

“Project Hail Mary” combines two familiar genres: the “man alone in space” movie with the dog (or cute creature) movie, taking the maxim “who rescued who?”

Arts & Entertainment

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